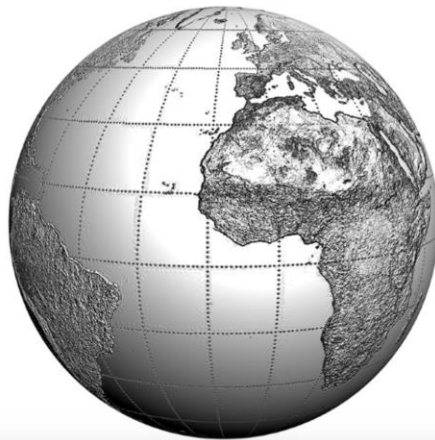


Diffusion of Religion



RRHS APHG
2019-2020

 MyFreePPT

Along with language, religion is the most influential element of culture on the formation of ethnic identity. It is also the most likely aspect of culture to lead to conflict along transition zones between cultural regions.

What is Religion?

- **Religion** is the belief in a higher power (supernatural being/deity) with controlling (or guiding) powers.
 - “Religious” means based on religion.
 - “Secular” means NOT based on religion



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Religion is a mentifact. It is the beliefs of a society. We see evidence of these beliefs through the artifacts (religious symbols) and sociofacts (social norms, ethics, and morals often reflect religious beliefs).

Public schools in the United States are **secular** – one of the founding principles of our government was that it was to **not** be based on the religious beliefs of any one group and that the citizens would have freedom of religion. This means they can practice any religion they so choose, or even none at all. This means the government is not supposed to support or endorse any one religion because there is separation of “church” (religion) and “state” (government). Since public schools are a service provided by the government, the curriculum is not based on religion. There have been several Supreme Court cases throughout our nation’s history that have challenged what it means to have separation of church and states in school – for instance the 1963 case of [Murray v. Curlett](#), in which the Supreme Court upheld that it is unconstitutional for public schools to mandate (require) reading of the Bible. Students are allowed read sacred texts on their own, pray, or practice their religion in their own way while at school, but the schools cannot require students to participate in these activities. Separation of Church and State may be more difficult to achieve than originally intended, however. Where do the rights of one person (based on their

religious beliefs) end and the rights of another begin? Many current Supreme Court hearings today are over the constitutionality of denying a person services based on their religion, race, ethnicity, or sexual orientation – these cases inherently are based on religious beliefs, and how those beliefs shape the social and legal norms set within society. Remember, too, that “public” or “state” mean government, and “private” means individuals. Private schools *can* have a religious component to the curriculum because those schools do not receive money from the government and are therefore not considered to be a service of the government.

Almost every major religion has religious schools (even if attendance is periodic) – these are ***institutions*** designed to promote the continuation of the beliefs to future generations.

Even though the U.S. government is secular, however, we can still see the influence of religion on our cultural practices. For examples, Sunday is traditionally reserved as a day of worship and rest. Until a few decades ago, there were even “**blue laws**” that prohibited the sale of certain products (such as alcohol, cosmetics, cars – basically anything considered a non-necessity) on Sundays. The blue laws have not been entirely erased, either – even today, stores and restaurants cannot sell or serve alcohol before noon on Sunday. If you go to the grocery store on a Sunday morning, you may see the aisles blocked off or the shelves covered.

Monotheistic or Polytheistic?

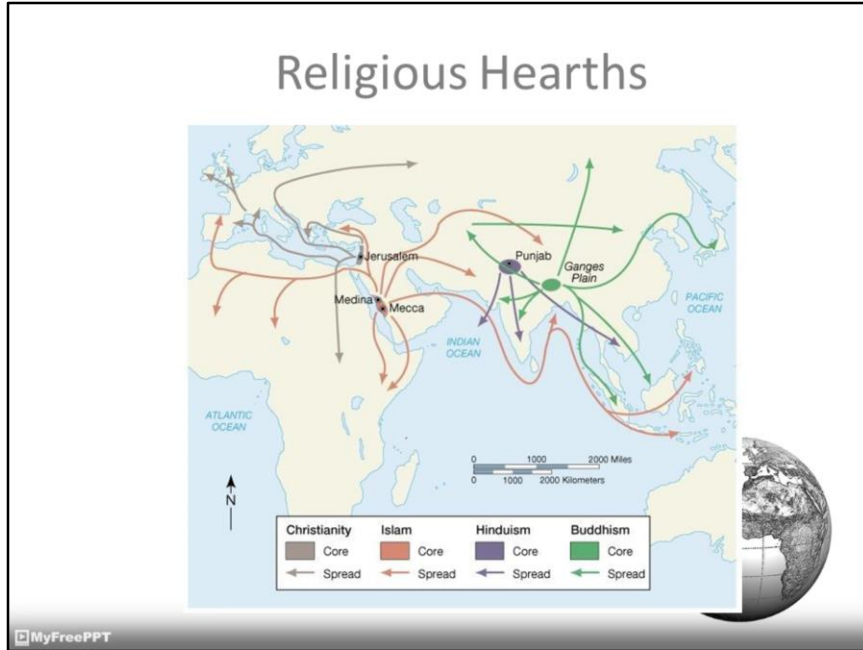
- One deity?
- Many deities?
- No deity?



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It is commonly agreed upon that Judaism, Christianity, Islam, and Sikhism are all **monotheistic** – they have just ONE deity. There is some debate over Hinduism, however, as to whether the religion is monotheistic (the same deity manifested in many different ways) or **polytheistic** (poly = many). Most indigenous/traditional religions (aka animist religions) are polytheistic, as the physical features of the earth are considered separate deities. Ancient Roman and Greek religions were also polytheistic (and their deities are still present in our cultures – the planets and other celestial features are named after them and they still appear in toponyms (i.e., Rome was names for Romulus, a central character of the origin story of the ancient Roman religion)).

Religious Hearths



Religious hearths are much easier to trace than linguistic hearths – this is mainly because most major modern religions were formed after writing, and therefore there are records and mentions of the places of origins for most major religions.

All of today's modern religions have their hearths in Asia, but can be divided between "Eastern Religions (and philosophies)" and "Western Religions"

The Eastern religions all originated in India – Hinduism and Sikhism in the Indus Valley Civilization, and Buddhism in northern India (modern-day Nepal).

The Western religions all originated in the Land of Canaan – the Fertile Crescent civilization of Southwest Asia (the Middle East).

Eastern Religions/Philosophies

- Hearths in India
 - Hinduism: Indus Valley
 - Buddhism: Himalayan foothills (modern day Nepal)
 - Sikhism: Punjab region



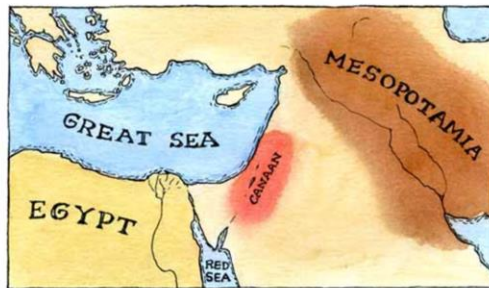
The Eastern religions have a circular view of life – each person is born, lives their life, dies, and is born again into a new life. The ultimate goal of these religions is to break out this cycle of life, death, and rebirth.

Hinduism is the oldest of the Eastern religions. Buddhism came out of Hinduism, following the teachings of Siddhartha Gautama – it should be noted that Buddhism does not have a deity, but is rather a set of guiding principles for how to live a good and right life.

Sikhism is the youngest of the modern-day major religions and is a blend between elements of Hinduism and elements of Islam. It originated on the boundary between these two faiths in the Punjab region of western India (along the border with Pakistan).

Western Religions

- Religions of Abraham
- Hearth in “Land of Canaan” – the Fertile Crescent
- Judaism
- Christianity
- Islam (Hearth in Medina/Mecca)



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Western religions are linear – a person is born, they live their life, and then proceed to the afterlife. Doctrines focus a great deal on what happens after death, and the deeds of the person during their life are thought to influence what happens to their soul after they die.

The western religions originated in the area of the Fertile Crescent (earliest known civilization) in Southwest Asia. Like the eastern religions, all the western religions are related as well. Judaism is the oldest of the Western religions, sometimes referred to as the religion of Abraham (central figure in all three western religions).

Christianity broke off and followed the teachings of Jesus of Nazareth (a Jew, believed by Christians to be God in human form) who followed the line of Abraham's son Isaac. Judaism and Christianity both have their hearths in modern-day Israel. The modern calendar reflects the founding of Christianity – the year 2019 A.D. is thought to be 2019 years following the estimated birth of Jesus. Different religions will often use their own calendars for their teachings and records, but the most common and daily used calendar reflects Christianity's impact on culture.

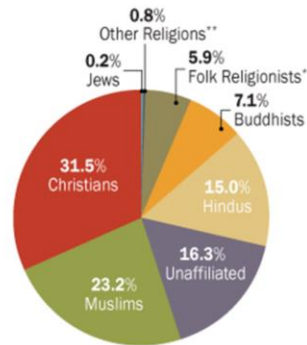
Islam later broke off of Judaism following the teachings of the Prophet Muhammed,

who followed the line of Abraham's other son Ishmael. Islam has its hearth in modern-day Saudi Arabia in the cities of Mecca and Medina.

Universalizing Religions

- Expansion Diffusion (primarily)
- Appeal to all people, regardless of geographic location
- Christianity, Islam, Buddhism, Sikhism

Size of Major Religious Groups, 2010
Percentage of the global population



*Includes followers of African traditional religions, Chinese folk religions, Native American religions and Australian aboriginal religions.

**Includes Bahai's, Jains, Sikhs, Shintoists, Taoists, followers of Tenrikyo, Wiccans, Zoroastrians and many other faiths.

Percentages may not add to 100 due to rounding.

Pew Research Center's Forum on Religion & Public Life • Global Religious Landscape, December 2012

Universalizing religions are those that appeal to anyone in any place, regardless of geographic location. The religions are not tied to a specific place on the planet (this is not to be confused with sacred sites, which are places of historical and religious significance).

It is relatively easy to convert to a universalizing religion. As such, universalizing religions typically have a well-dispersed pattern that reach all over the world. The two most-practiced religions are Christianity (estimated 2.3 billion) and Islam (estimated 1.8 billion followers) – note that the “unaffiliated” on the chart above indicates those who identify as non-religious.

Universalizing religions (in order of adherents)

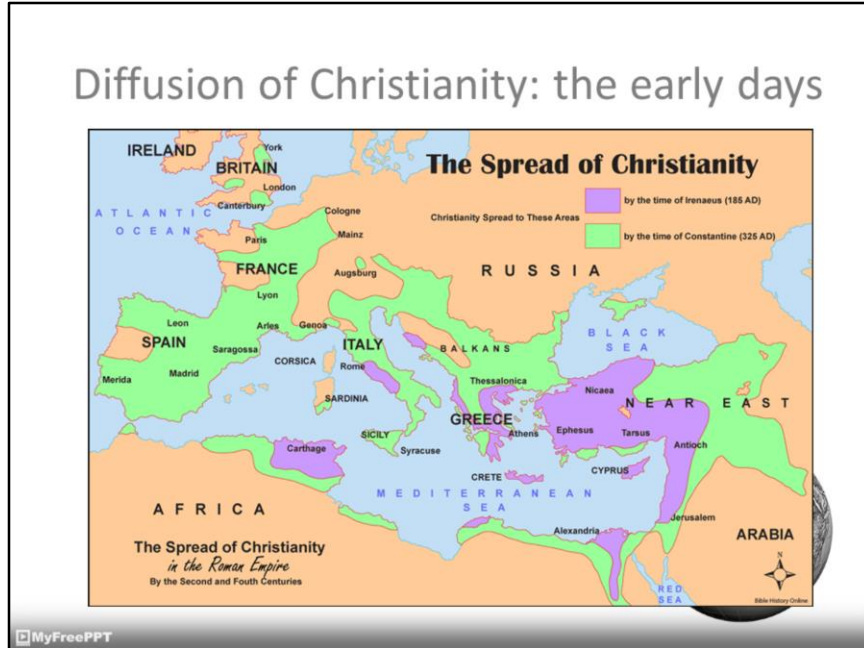
Christianity

Islam

Buddhism

Sikhism

Diffusion of Christianity: the early days



Colonialism

Relocation diffusion AND hierarchical diffusion

"God, Glory, and Gold"

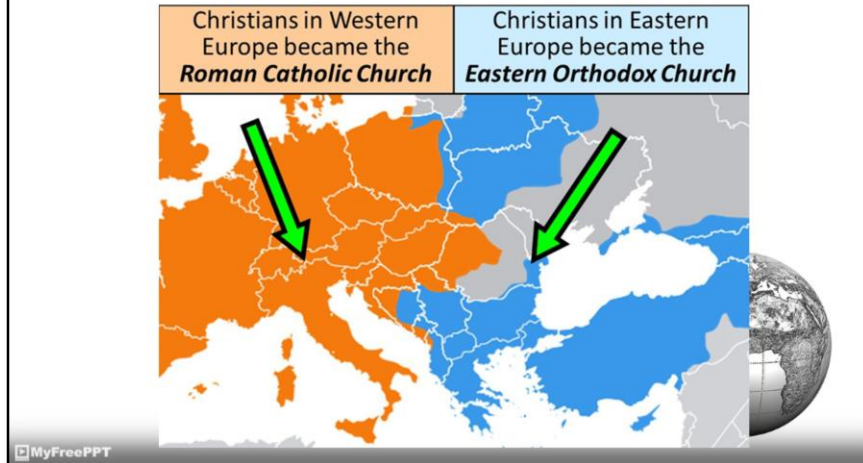
Missionaries

Contagious diffusion

The diffusion of Christianity began with colonialism – Roman colonialism of Europe and North Africa. The Roman Emperor Constantine converted to Christianity in the 4th century (300s) and declared that all his subjects also convert. Roman colonists carried the religion with them all over the Empire, and in doing so they usurped (took over) many traditional sacred sites and gave them a Christian significance, often by burying important sacred relics (artifacts of cultural/religious significance) or the bodies of important religious figures in those places.

Christianity: The Great Schism

- Split of Christian Church



The Great Schism occurred in the year 1054, was actually the result of a split of the Roman Empire into the Roman Empire (Roman Catholic) with a capital at Rome; and the Byzantine Empire (Eastern Orthodox) with its capital at Constantinople (modern-day Istanbul, Turkey).

"Catholic" means "the one true/universal"

"Orthodox" means "pure and traditional"

Why the split?

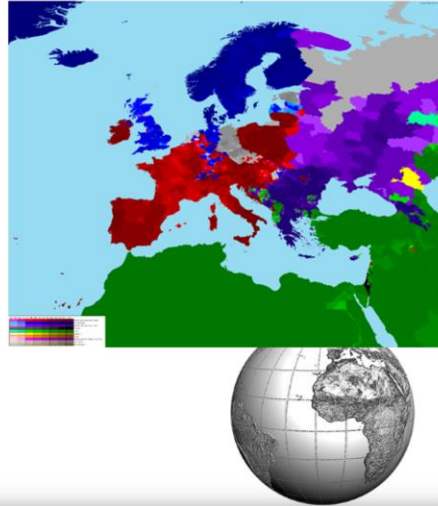
The Pope (in Rome) and the Patriarch of Constantinople excommunicated each other (each kicked the other out of the church) over debate about who had jurisdiction (right to preside) over the Church, if leavened or unleavened bread (with yeast or without) should be used during the Eucharist (sacrament of communion), and disagreements over the procession of the Holy Spirit (part of the Holy Trinity; God in three forms, a core structure of the Christian faith).

Impact of the East/West Split – the Eastern branch spread eastward, and with it took the Greek language. The Western Branch (Catholicism) spread westward, and with it took Latin (and Romance languages).

Constantinople fell in 1453 to the Ottoman Empire, who were Muslim and spread the Islamic religion into the area, leading to overlapping regions of Christians and Muslims (and conflict occurs when regions overlap)

The Protestant Reformation

- Martin Luther, Germany
- No longer recognize authority of the Pope as leader of the church
- Led to wars and social discrimination
- Protestant denominations form



The western branch of the Christian church had another split – this one in 1517 when a Catholic monk named Martin Luther publically posted his grievances against the Catholic Church and the Pope. One of his biggest complaints against the church was the opulence and grandeur of the Vatican and other sites. He said that the clergy were gaining all the wealth from the sale of indulgences. An “indulgence” was part of medieval Catholicism and a major trigger to the Protestant Reformation. Basically, indulgences could be purchased in order to reduce the punishment you were owed for your sins. Buy an indulgence for a loved one, and they would go to heaven and not suffer eternal punishment in hell. Luther argued that such forgiveness could not be bought, and the church was swindling people out of the money.

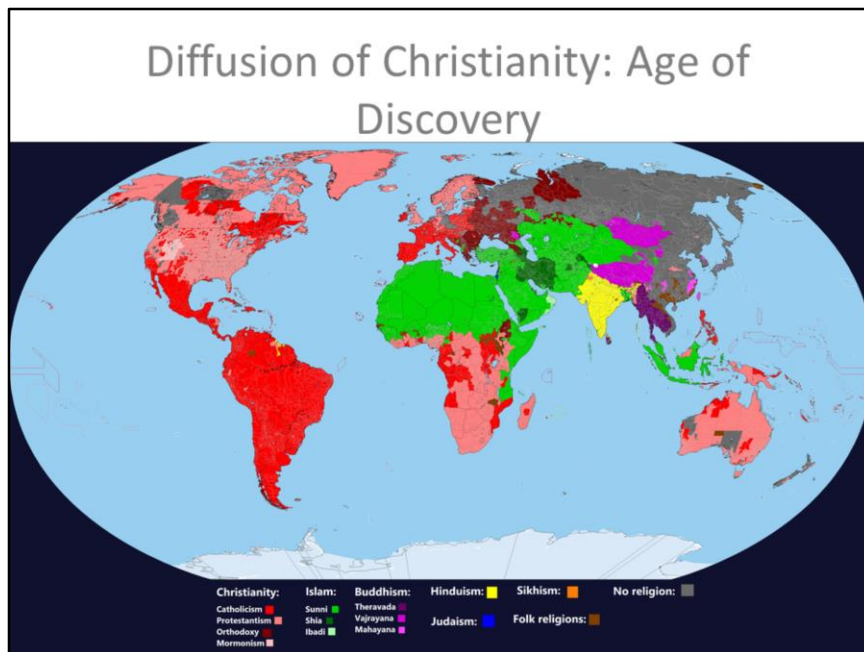
As you can expect, the Pope was not happy about this negative criticism, and excommunicated Luther.

This split between the Catholics and Protestants kicked off a series of wars across Europe that ended with the Thirty Years War of 1618-1648 that killed 1/3 of Germany’s population. Social discrimination against protestants in Germany and other countries continued well into the 19th century and were a major push factor for migration to North America.

Today, there is a global split between Protestants and Catholics in the Western world – North America and Northern Europe are mostly protestant, while the rest of Western Europe (and their colonies is Latin America) are predominantly Catholic.

The map above shows religion in Europe – the Red areas are Catholic, while the Blue parts are Protestant. (Purple areas are Eastern Orthodox, and Green is Islamic)

Other groups also broke off from the Catholic church and are considered protestant – the Anglicans are the Church of England, who broke off after Henry VIII rejected the authority of the Pope (he was then excommunicated, as well). Episcopalians are the American version. John Calvin, the Anabaptists, and other groups also formed varying **denominations** (sub-branches within the greater “protestant” label)



Spread of “God” while in search of Gold and Glory.

We’ve already talked about colonization – Religions were a major cultural change that occurred as a result of Europeans conquering different parts of the world and contributed the majority of the spread of the Christian religion today. Notice the different shading for Christianity – the darker red is Catholic, while the pink shades are protestant. Sub-Saharan Africa is showing as protestant due to contemporary diffusion – missionaries travel to the area to do service projects and actively seek to convert people to their religion.

Cultural Landscape of Christianity



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There is a great deal of variety in the cultural landscape of the varying Christian branches, but some distinctive features are evident:

Catholic churches and Anglican/Episcopal churches (especially historical examples – see above right) are very grand and ornate. These are huge structures, mostly made of stone and many are hundreds of years old. Today they are important cultural and historical significance within their countries – for example, Notre Dame in Paris (Catholic cathedral), St. Paul's Cathedral and Westminster Abbey in London (Anglican), and the St. Paul's Basilica at the Vatican are all well known historical cathedrals. You can google “famous cathedrals” to see more examples.

Protestant churches tend to be much more modest, especially considering that one of the main arguments of the Protestant Reformation was that the Catholic were getting wealthy by charging parishioners for forgiveness of their sins. The image above left is an example of a simple church in a rural setting.

A common feature of architecture for BOTH Catholics and Protestants is the steeple – A steeple, in architecture, is a tall tower on a building, topped by a spire and often incorporating a belfry and other components. Steeples are very common on Christian

churches and cathedrals and the use of the term generally connotes a religious structure. A bell tower may either be part of the steeple or a separate tall tower which contains a large bell used to sound the beginning of worship.

The cross is the most well-known symbol of Christianity. The two images above are examples of crosses from Eastern Orthodox (left) and Western branches (both Catholic and Protestant, right).

Clothing is another artifact of the cultural landscape – in the Christian church, there are not typically any prescribed clothes of the general population (they are mostly influenced by popular culture anyway); however, the religious leaders do have ceremonial clothes that they wear in both the Catholic and Eastern Orthodox branches, as well as within many protestant denominations (i.e., Lutheran, Methodist, etc.).

Sacred Sites of Christianity

- Jerusalem
- Bethlehem

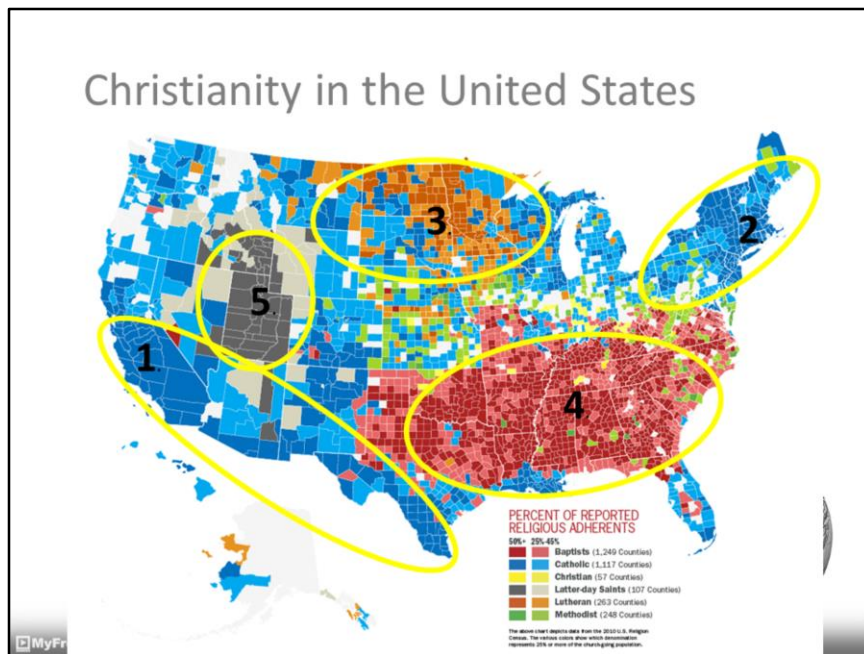


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The two most holy sites in Christianity are located at its hearth – Jerusalem and Bethlehem.

Jerusalem is the location of the Temple Mount, which is where the Church of the Holy Sepulcher, believed to be the location of the tomb where Jesus of Nazareth was buried following his crucifixion (execution by cross). Jesus was said to teach his disciples and pray daily on the steps of the Temple. Jerusalem is also the location of the Garden of Gethsemane and the Hall of the Last Supper, both important sites in the days leading up to his death.

Bethlehem is the birthplace of Jesus of Nazareth.



As mentioned earlier, the United States is predominantly Protestant. The Protestant branch of Christianity is broken down into **denominations** (sub-branches). On the map above, I have circled 5 regions in order to highlight the pattern of religion within the country.

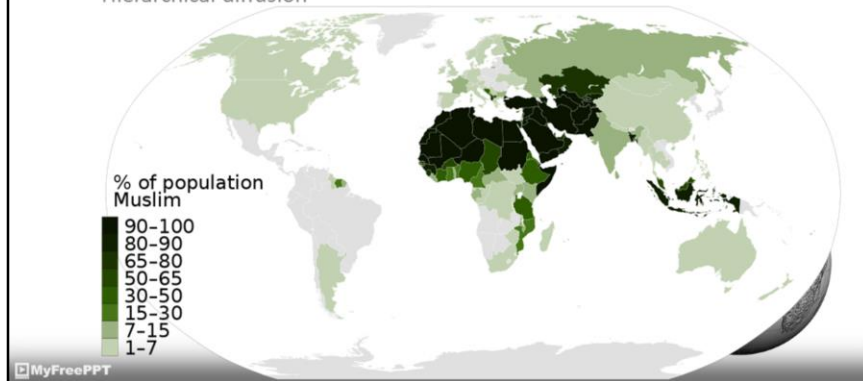
1. (Southwest U.S., along the border with Mexico) – this region is predominantly Catholic. This pattern goes back to the Spanish settlements and from when it was part of Mexico. Today, this region is also a destination for migrants coming from Latin American countries, who are also Catholic.
2. (the Northeast) This region is also predominantly Catholic, but unlike the Southwest region, the catholic predominance formed primarily due to immigration from Ireland and Italy.
3. (Upper Midwest) – The upper Midwest (Minnesota, North Dakota, South Dakota) formed due to migration from Scandinavian countries (northern Europe). It is predominantly Lutheran.
4. (the South) – this region is predominantly Baptist, a denomination that formed

about a century after the other protestant denominations that hold the mainstream Protestants did not do enough to right the perceived wrongs of the Catholic church. The separatist became known as “Baptist Separatists” and eventually just “Baptist”. The Southern Baptist Convention is the governmental body that oversees most Baptist churches, so many times people will refer to this region of the U.S. as “Southern Baptist”.

5. (Utah, Idaho – intermountain west) – this region is predominantly Mormon. Mormons do not belong to neither the Catholics nor the protestants, but are a **sect** (small sub-division) of Christianity. There are fundamental differences in beliefs of what happened after Jesus of Nazareth was crucified. This sect of Christianity began in the eastern portion of the U.S., but due to discrimination and other issues, the group moved westward, settling in Utah (Salt Lake City). From there, it has spread into much of Utah, Arizona, Colorado, and Idaho. Many Mormon youth participate in mission trips around the world as part of their religious education.

Diffusion of Islam

- Indian Ocean Trade
 - Contagious diffusion
- Adoption by rulers
 - Hierarchical diffusion



As you learned in the “Historical Diffusion Notes”, Islam diffused around the Indian Ocean basin via trade routes. It also spread contagiously across North Africa via overland trade routes. When rulers adopted the religion and declared that all their subjects also convert, that is an example of hierarchical diffusion.

North Africa, Southwest Asia, and Indonesia (Southeast Asia) have the highest percentages of Muslims within their countries, but there are also significant populations in India (minority religion following the Great Partition of India and Pakistan), The United States and Australia, (relocation and contagious diffusion), and into Russia (The Caucasus Mountain region that used to be controlled by the Ottoman Empire – Hierarchical and contagious diffusion). There is also a significant proportion in France due to relocation diffusion (recent migrants).

The Schism of Islam

- Occurred shortly after Muhammed's death
 - Who should be his successor?
 - Heir?
 - Elected leader?
- Two main branches:
 - Sunni
 - Shi'ite (or Shia)

The distribution of Shia & Sunni Muslims in the Middle East



#StatistaCharts Source: Channel 4

INDEPENDENT statista

Islam has also gone through schism – the cause of debate over the rightful successor of Muhammed as the head of the Islamic religion.

The Shia (or Shi'ite) branch maintained that the successor should be a direct descendent of the Prophet.

The Sunni branch argued that the leader should be elected.

Today, the Sunni branch of the religion is the most widespread worldwide, while the Shia branch is more concentrated into Iraq, Iran, and Lebanon. There is significant **intrafaith conflict** between the two groups (conflict within the same religion).

Cultural Landscape of Islam



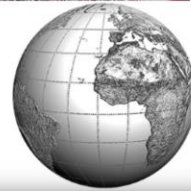
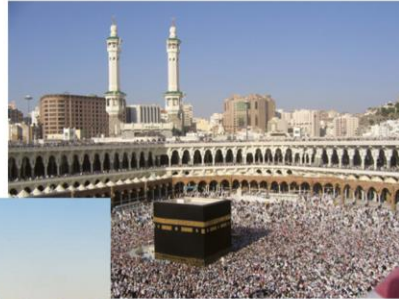
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Architecture in the Islamic cultural landscape has two distinctive design features – the domed roof and the minaret. A Minaret is a tall slender tower, typically part of a mosque, with a balcony from which a muezzin calls Muslims to prayer.

Clothing in the Islamic cultural landscape is more traditional when compared to popular culture styles in other places. Depending on the country/ethnicity it may be relatively more or less conservative and traditional than others. The Hijab (head covering) is a typical article of clothing worn within many Muslim cultures.

Sacred Sites of Islam

- Mecca (the Kaaba)
- Medina
- Jerusalem



Mecca: The Kaaba (or Ka'bah) is a small rectangular shrine located near the center of the Great Mosque in Mecca. It is considered the most sacred spot on Earth by most Muslims. Muslims orient themselves toward this shrine during their daily prayers, bury their dead facing it, and is a major destination of the Hajj (pilgrimage that is one of the core tenants of Islam).

Medina: second holiest city of Islam after Mecca. It is from this place that the Prophet Muhammed established the Muslim community after he was forced to leave Mecca in the year 622 (year 1 according to the Muslim calendar). He is also buried at the main mosque of the city.

Jerusalem: location of the Dome of the Rock and Al-Aqsa Mosque are located on the site of the Temple Mount. It is considered the third holiest site in Islam and the place where Muhammad arrived on the night he ascended to heaven and spoke with Allah.

Islam in the United States

- 3rd largest religion in the U.S.
- 3.45 million Muslims
 - Up to 25% are converts



Islam has the 3rd largest number of religious adherents (followers) in the U.S. They are mostly centered around urban areas (as follows the trend of the population, since over 80% of the U.S. lives in urban areas). Michigan is home to the largest concentration (biggest percentage of total population), while California is home to the largest number of Muslims. The map above shows the distribution of Muslim Centers in the U.S.

Up to 25% of the Muslims in the U.S. are converts, the others are immigrants or children of immigrants who were born into the religion.

Muslims have faced protests and discrimination from varying groups within the U.S., particularly in the aftermath of the September 11th terrorist attacks, which were carried out by radical Muslim extremists from other countries.

Buddhism

- No recognized deity
- Guiding principle: Four Noble Truths
 - Practice Morality, meditation, and wisdom to reach enlightenment



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Unlike other religions, followers of Buddhism don't acknowledge a supreme god or deity. The word "Buddha", the name given to the founder, means "enlightened one." Followers believe that the path to enlightenment is attained by practicing morality (good life), meditation, and wisdom could achieve enlightenment, and therefore break free of the cycle of life and death. Those who are enlightened reach Nirvana,, the ultimate state of bliss that transcends suffering.

Diffusion of Buddhism

- Hearth in northern India (modern-day Nepal)
- Concentrated in Southeast and East Asia



was founded by Siddhartha Gautama (“the Buddha”) more than 2,500 years ago in northern India (modern-day Nepal). The religion has historically been most prominent in East and Southeast Asia, but its influence is growing the West. Many Buddhist ideas and philosophies overlap with those of other faiths.

The map above shows the distribution of the major branches of Buddhism.

Theravada Buddhism is the most conservative/orthodox branch of Buddhism. It recognizes no deity. In following the sacred texts of Buddhism, a person can achieve Nirvana (enlightenment and freedom from the cycle of life and death). This branch of Buddhism is most common in Sri Lanka, Thailand, Laos, Cambodia, and Myanmar.

Mahayana Buddhism has made changes to the original teachings of the Buddha, and believe that every person has the ability to access Nirvana. It is mostly practiced in Nepal, Japan, China, Tibet, and Korea.

Cultural Landscape of Buddhism



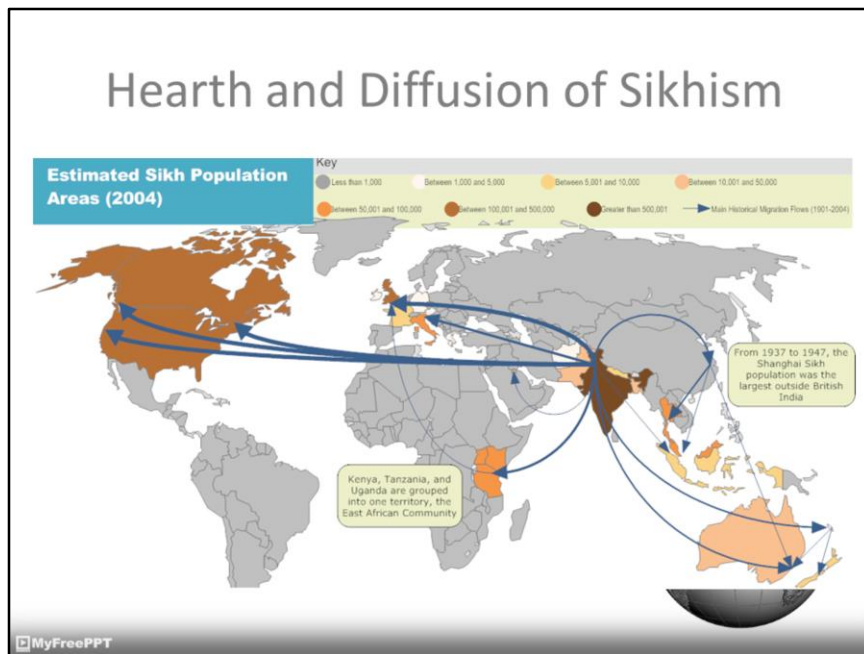
One of the most recognizable symbols of the Buddhist cultural landscape is the Buddha statue.

Buddhist temples are called “wat” and “pagoda” They generally can be classified as one of three varieties:

1. Stupas – bell-shaped structures that contain a holy relic or scripture
2. Temples – places of workshop somewhat similar to a church
3. Monasteries, which have living quarters and mediation cells for monks

Pictured above: lower left – a Buddha statue in Thailand, lower right: the Shwedagon pagoda in Myanmar, upper right: Buddhist monks in meditation.

Hearth and Diffusion of Sikhism



Sikhism is a monotheistic religion founded about 600 years ago (the youngest of the major religions) in **the Punjab region** of India by Guru Nanak.

Sikhism broke from Hinduism in part because of its rejection of the Caste System (strict social stratification).

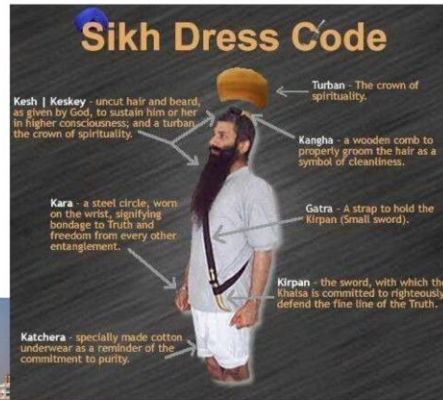
Sikhs believe in reincarnation and karma concepts found in Hinduism and Buddhism; however, in Sikhism, both karma and liberation from the cycle of life and death are modified by the concept of god's grace (a concept of the western religions). In this way, it takes on elements of both eastern and western religions.

There are about 27 million followers world wide. The vast majority of Sikhs are in India, but largely due to relocation migration there are between 100,000 – 500,000 Sikhs in the U.S.

Cultural Landscape of Sikhism



MyFreePPT



The Golden temple is a culturally important site in the Sikh religion (photo lower left). The Sikh also have a prescribed dress code, and following it is considered to be essential to practicing the faith. Sikh men are easily recognized by their clothing and turban (head covering that differs from the head coverings of Islamic culture).

Sikhism in the United States



The U.S. has the second largest population of Sikhs in the world.

Since Sikh dress is an inherent part of the religion, Sikh soldiers and police officers are permitted to modify their uniforms to fit their religious practices. Unfortunately, the Sikh policeman pictured here (center) was killed in the line of duty in Houston just a few weeks ago (September 2019).

Sikhs in the United States have been targets of racial/religious attacks and discrimination, often being confused for Muslims in the wake of the September 11th terrorist attacks.

Ethnic Religions

- People are born into the religion
- Tied closely to ethnicity
- Geographic location is central to religion
- Examples:
 - Hinduism
 - Judaism



MyFreePPT

Unlike universalizing religions, which are open to anybody in any place and are easy to convert to, ethnic religions are closely tied to an ethnicity and geographic location. While universalizing religions diffuse through all forms of diffusion (some relocation, but mostly expansion), ***ethnic religions spread primarily through relocation diffusion.***

Hearth and Diffusion of Hinduism



The hearth of Hinduism is in the Indus River Valley. The exact date of origin is unknown.

Hinduism has spread to other places, such as the United States, through relocation diffusion.

Depending on who you ask, Hinduism may be considered either polytheistic (with many deities with different names) or monotheistic (one deity), but in many forms (the one deity is represented in many forms and by many names).

Cultural Landscape of Hinduism



One of the most recognizable aspects of the cultural landscape of the Hindu religion are the brightly colored shrines, typically adorned with flowers and other ornament (top left photo). Offerings of food are also common.

The Rangoli (lower left photo) is an art form, originating in the Indian subcontinent, in which patterns are created on the floor or the ground using materials such as colored rice, dry flour, colored sand or flower petals. It is usually made during Diwali or Tihar, Onam, Pongal and other Hindu festivals and celebrations.

The Sari (or saree) is the most recognizable clothing of the Hindu culture, though due to cultural diffusion women in other cultures also wear this style of clothing. Saris may be simple and made of cotton for everyday wear, or very ornate with intricate embroidery and bead work for celebrations.

There are few cemeteries in Hindu culture, as the main burial practice is cremation.

The Caste System

- Now illegal
- Strict social stratification
 - Based on birth

Brahma and the origins of caste



Source: Alamy

BBC

In 1948, negative discrimination on the basis of caste was banned by law (made illegal) and further enshrined in the Indian constitution; however the system continues to be practiced in India with devastating social effects. This is very similar to how racial segregation and discrimination were banned in the U.S. in the 1960s, but still continues in practice today because these institutionalized class/race divides can take generations to fade out of practice. It may not be as obvious/deliberate as it once was, but it is still an issue within the society.

“Caste” is actually an English word used to describe the hierarchical class system.

A person was born into their caste and there was no social mobility (moving from one class to another) – this affected a person’s ability to go to school, who they could marry, and what jobs they could have.

Brahmins were said to have Sattva qualities. They were priests.

Kshatriyas were inherently Rajas and Sattva, the ruling and military elite. Their role was to protect society by fighting in wartime and governing in peacetime.

Vaishyas were believed to possess Rajas qualities inherently. They were agriculturalists, cattle rearers, and traders.

Shudras were held to possess Tamas qualities inherently. They served the other Varnas and were the original slave-like or peasant-like population.

Dalits were the class of untouchables. They did menial and despised jobs and were thus believed to be “polluted.”

We can look at other cultures and see how these same classes arose in different ways. They seem to be systems that form along with social groupings, which we could see as naturally arising systems. Social stratification was, in theory, one of the most important parts of the development of early civilizations.

European society has historically been divided by:

Churches (the Pope was considered the highest ranked member of society – He crowned the king)

Kings, Aristocracy, and Their Army

Merchants and Oligarchs

Peasants

Slaves

Sacred Sites of Hinduism



Varanasi is a major religious hub located in Uttar Pradesh (a state in India) along the banks of the Ganges River. It is recognized as the holiest of the seven sacred cities in Hinduism. Varanasi has been a cultural center of northern India for several thousand years, and is closely associated with the Ganges River. Varanasi is also an important site in Buddhism

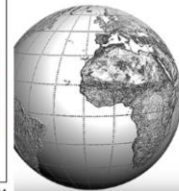
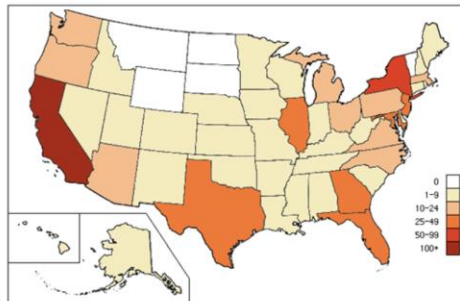
The Ganges River itself is considered sacred and is personified as the goddess Gaṅgā. It is believed that bathing in the river causes the remission of sins and facilitates Moksha (liberation from the cycle of life and death), and that the water of the Ganges is considered very pure.

Millions of pilgrims travel each year to the Sri Ranganathaswamy Temple in Srirangam, India. It dates back to the 10th century.

Hinduism in the United States

- 4th largest religion in the U.S.
 - Relocation diffusion important factor
 - 2.23 million adherents in U.S.

Distribution of Hindu Centers in the U.S.
Research in Progress: 702 Centers, Fall 2004

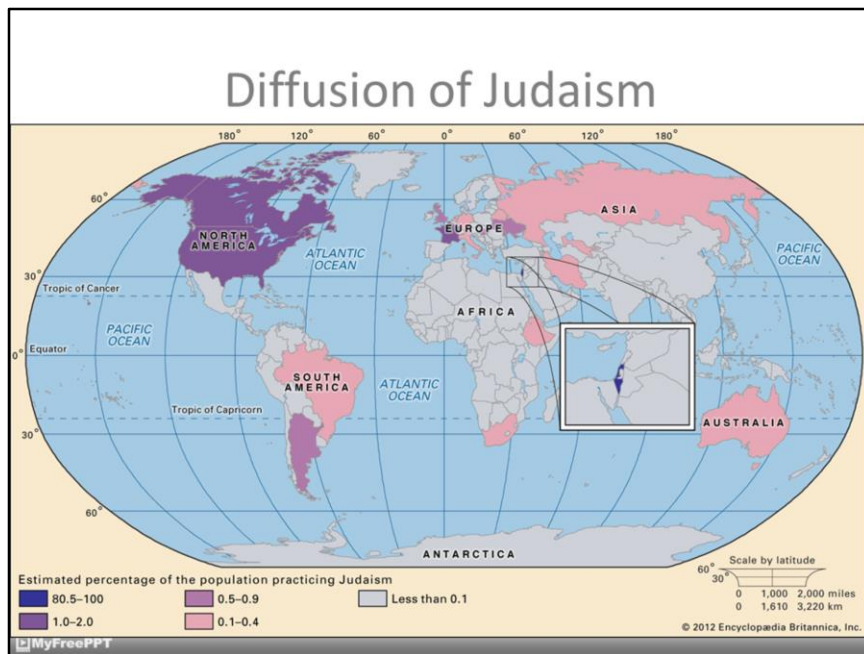


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Source - The Pluralism Project at Harvard University: Directory of Religious Centers © 2004
<http://www.pluralism.org/directory>

80% of Hindu populations in the United States are located in major urban centers with more than a million people.

Hindu presence in the United States was extremely limited until the passage of the Immigration and Nationality Act of 1965, which opened up immigration into the U.S. of people from East, South, and Southeast Asia. Migration from these regions had been legally restricted prior to 1965. The growing number of Hindus in the United States is evidence of changing migration patterns since the 1990s.



In terms of numbers, Judaism is NOT one of the world's major religions. However, in terms of geographic and historical significance, Judaism has been one of the most impactful in history. Major centuries-long wars were fought over control over Judaism's holiest sites (because they are also holy sites for Christianity and Islam) – The Crusades.

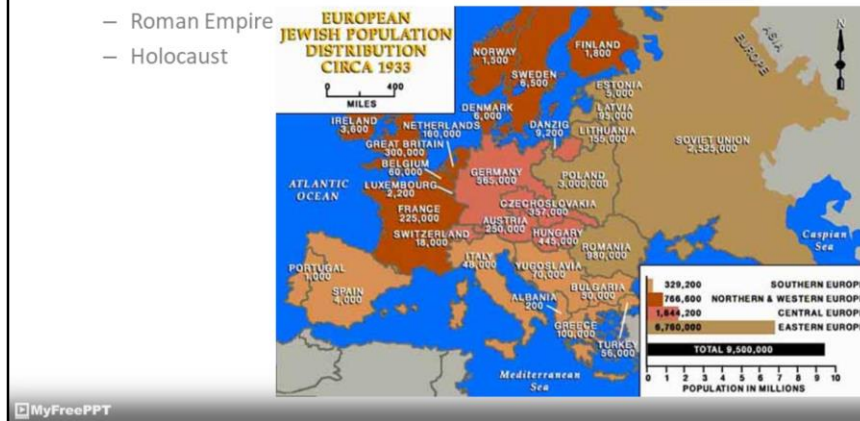
Oldest of the Western religions, and Christianity and Islam both developed out of Judaism.

2nd largest religion group in the U.S.

Modern distribution attributed to two major diasporas: The Roman Exile and the Holocaust.

The Jewish Diasporas

- Diffusion of Judaism due to forced migration
 - Roman Empire
 - Holocaust



Diaspora means “scattering” – a population has a diaspora when they are “scattered” into new geographic locations.

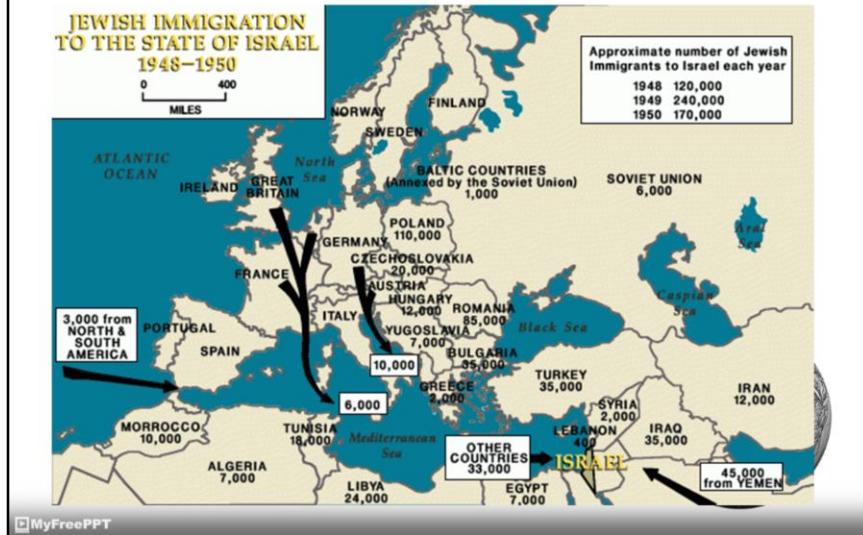
The war between the Romans and the Jews in the first century A.D. (sometimes referred to as CE – current era – since A.D. is a Latin phrase that signifies the Christian calendar. A.D. stands for *anno Domini*, which translates as “in the year of our Lord”). The Romans sacked Jerusalem (the hearth of Judaism) and destroyed the Second Temple (which replaced the first temple after it was destroyed) and sent the Jewish people into exile in the furthest reaches of the Roman Empire (mostly across Europe).

The other major diaspora, and the one that led to the current distribution of Jewish peoples around the world today, was the Holocaust that began in the 1930s under Hitler’s Nazi regime in Germany. Jewish people were forced to flee for their lives as their loved ones were gathered up and taken to “Concentration” camps, which later turned into death camps in one of the most well-known and largest genocides in modern history. It was a systematic, state sponsored, massacre of an estimated 6 million people. It did not just occur within Germany, but also in allied countries where the Nazi regime also gained power. The map above shows the distribution of the Jewish population in 1933, the year the Nazi party gained control. There were just

under an estimated 10 million Jewish that year, and an estimated 6 million of them were killed.

Many countries, including the United States, refused large numbers of Jewish refugees, citing the Great Depression (which was a global economic crisis) and increased strain on the economy as well as fears of communist spies infiltrating the groups as major causes of concern. It took several years for many those who had fled to find a permanent home.

Modern Day Distribution of Judaism



The modern state of Israel was created in 1948. Migration into the new state was open to all people of Jewish ethnicity. As these people came from all over the world, Hebrew, the Liturgical language of Judaism was an obvious lingua franca and set as an official language of the new state.

Today, the majority of Jewish people of the world live in Israel, with the 2nd largest population in the United States.

Cultural Landscape of Judaism



The daidel is a four-sided spinning top, played with during the Jewish holiday of Hanukkah (pictured above left).

The star of David is a six-pointed figure consisting of two interlaced equilateral triangles, used as a Jewish and Israeli symbol. It is featured prominently on the Israeli flag (necklace, above center)

A Yarmulke is a skullcap worn in public by Orthodox Jewish men or during prayer by other Jewish men. This is typically the only item of clothing that is identifiable as “Jewish” in most societies; however, Orthodox Jews (the more traditional branch of the religion) do wear more traditional clothing on a daily basis.

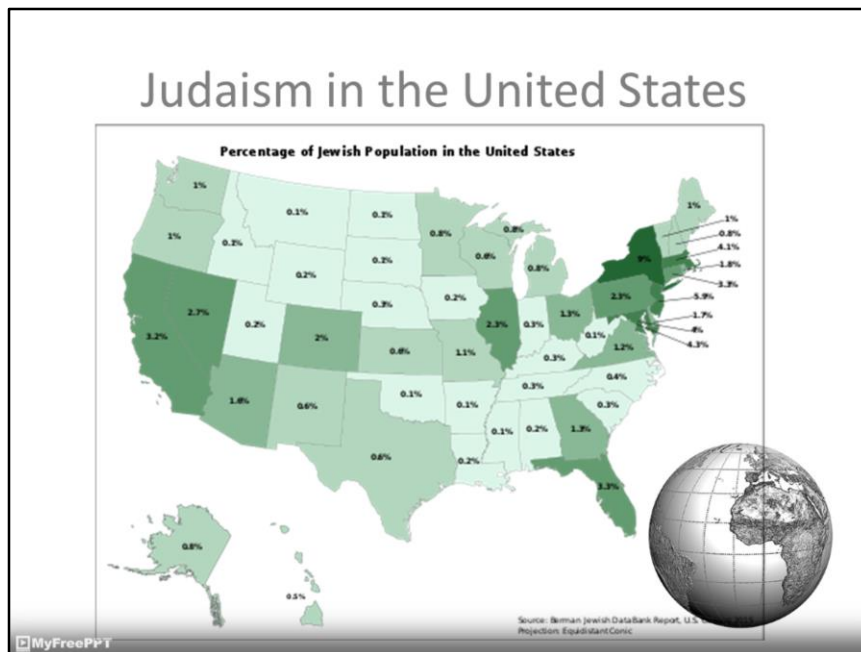
Sacred Sites of Judaism



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Does this image look familiar? It should. It's the Temple Mount – it was also featured on the Sacred Site of Christianity AND the sacred sites of Islam slide.

The wall in the forefront is the Western Wall – the holiest site in Judaism. The complex on which the Dome of the Rock (Islamic holy site) sits is thought to be the location of the first and second Jewish Temple (both destroyed in momentous events in Jewish history). The Western Wall is all that remains of these temples. The Western Wall is considered holy due to its connection to the Temple Mount. Because of the Temple Mount entry restrictions, the Wall is the holiest place where Jews are permitted to pray, though the holiest site in the Jewish faith lies behind it.



The Northeast (New York, Pennsylvania, New Jersey, Connecticut, Maryland, Massachusetts, Rhode Island, and Delaware) have the largest concentration of Jewish peoples in the United States.

Most Jewish people in the U.S. today are American-born descendants of immigrants who migrated from Central and Eastern Europe during the diaspora in the 1930s through World War II.

The Jewish population in the United States is estimated to be between five and eight million, depending on how “Jewish” is defined – is it a religious affiliation, ethnicity, or nationality? People who are Jewish identify as being Jewish whether they are religious or not, which is why there is such a wide estimate of the population.

Syncretic Religions

- Mixture of multiple religions
 - May be religion itself
 - OR celebrations and rituals have blended components



Religious syncretism exhibits blending of two or more religious belief systems into a new system, or the incorporation into a religious tradition of beliefs from unrelated traditions. Examples of syncretism include Japanese Shintoism (combination of Buddhism and traditional/native religions of Japan), Sikhism (a blend between Eastern and Western religions), the Haitian religions discussed earlier in the unit, and many more.

An example of a syncretic religious custom is Carnival in Brazil. As with many other Catholic cultures, the time leading up to the beginning of the Lent fast includes big parties and celebrations – Mardi Gras is the most well known of these events, culminating in “Fat Tuesday”, the last evening before Ash Wednesday, which signifies the beginning of the fast. Carnival had its origins in Portugal, and when the Portuguese colonized Brazil, their culture diffused. There, it blended with many native cultures which infused their own traditions into the celebrations and a new, blended, tradition was born. A float in a Carnival parade is pictured above, left.

Dia de los muertos is another well-known example of a syncretic religious celebration. In Mexican culture, death is considered a natural part of the cycle of life, and the “Day of the Dead” is a day to celebrate the memories of loved ones. Scholars

trace the origins of the modern Mexican holiday to indigenous observances dating back hundreds of years and to an Aztec festival dedicated to the goddess Mictecacihuatl. In the Catholic tradition, November 1 is “All Saints Day”, a religious holiday that celebrates Christian saints. All Hallows Eve (Halloween) is the night before, and Dia de los Muertos is the day after. Dia de los muertos celebrates the ordinary people who have died, not just the saints. The most iconic decoration of Dia de los Muertos is the sugar skull, which represents departed souls. Pictured above right is a man dressed in costume for a Dia de los Muertos parade.